



**WSQ**  
CUSTOMER SERVICE

**COURSE SLIDES · WSQ**

# Improve Your Business with Excellent Customer Service

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WSQ Course Code: TGS-2025056191 · 1-Day Hands-On Training

Skills Framework TSC: Customer Service Innovation Management (EPW-CEX-3034-1.1)

Conducted by Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd · UEN 201200696W

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COURSE ADMINISTRATION

# Welcome & Housekeeping

# Digital Attendance (Mandatory)

1

## Three scans, every course day

AM at the start, PM after lunch, and again before the assessment.

2

## The trainer shows the QR

Generated live from the SSG TRAQOM portal — it changes each session.

3

## Scan with your phone camera

Open the camera, point at the QR, tap the link and submit.

4

## Use your registered details

The NRIC/FIN you enrolled with, or the record will not match.

5

## 75% attendance minimum

Below this you are not eligible for the assessment or for funding.

6

## Tell the trainer immediately

If your scan fails or you arrive late — it cannot be fixed after the day.

Digital attendance is a mandatory SSG funding requirement — it is not the same thing as the TRAQOM feedback survey.

# About the Trainer



## Your Trainer

General Trainer template —  
to be completed by the trainer

NAME

TITLE / DESIGNATION

QUALIFICATIONS

AREAS OF EXPERTISE

TRAINING & INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

CONTACT

# About the Trainer



**Dr. Alfred Ang**

Principal Trainer  
Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

## ROLE

Principal Trainer, Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

## BACKGROUND

PhD — 20+ years of industry and training experience across service quality, business operations and technology.

## DELIVERS

WSQ courses on customer service, service branding, business improvement and digital skills.

## FOUNDER

Founder and lead instructor at Tertiary Infotech / Tertiary Courses.

# Let's Know Each Other

1

## Your name and organisation

And the role you play day to day.

2

## Who your customers are

External, internal, or both — most people have both.

3

## A recent interaction that went badly

What happened, and what you think caused it.

4

## One that went well

What made the difference on that occasion?

5

## Your channels

Counter, phone, email, chat — where do you spend most of your time?

6

## What you want from today

One thing you want to do differently tomorrow.

# Ground Rules

1

Set your mobile phone to silent mode.

2

Participate actively — no question is too small.

3

Mutual respect: agree to disagree.

4

One conversation at a time.

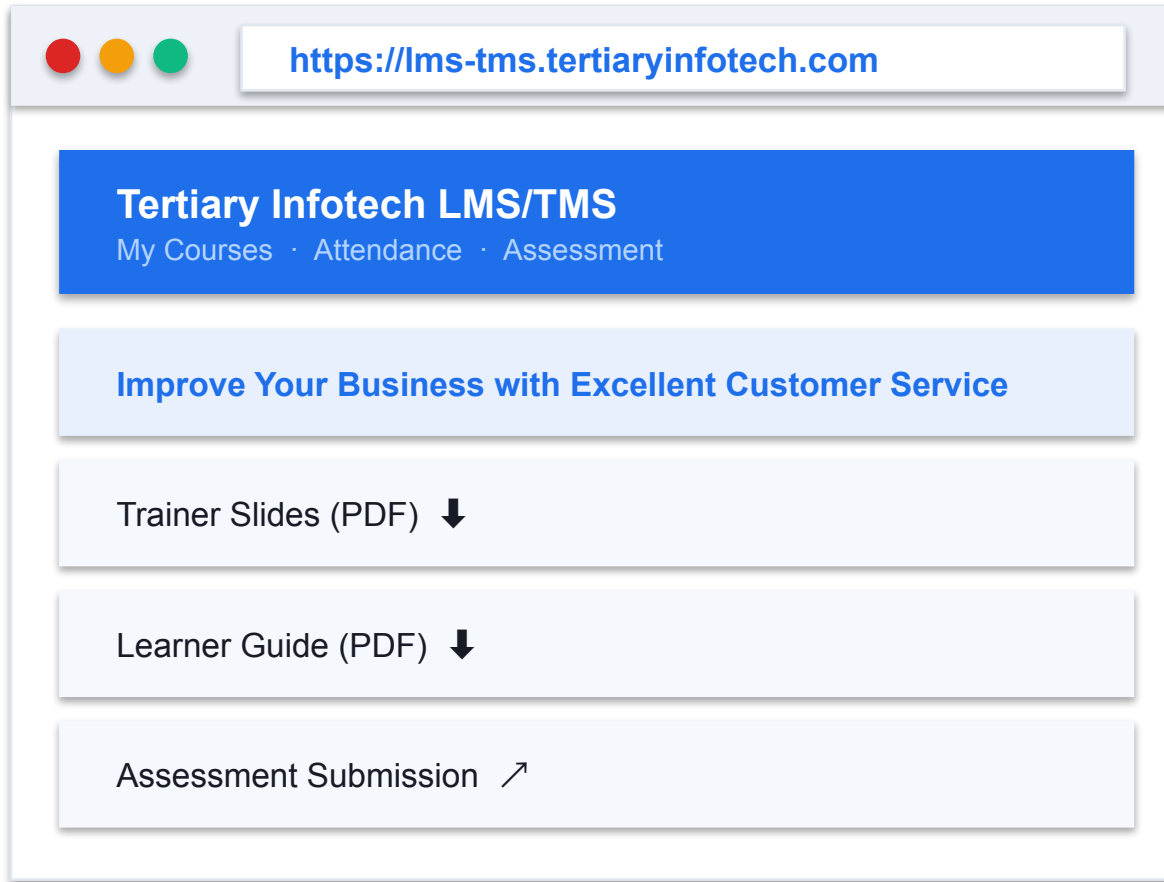
5

Be punctual; return from breaks on time.

6

75% attendance is required for funding.

# Download Course Material



## 1 Sign in

lms-tms.tertiaryinfotech.com — log in with your registered email (OTP or password).

## 2

### Open your course

Select 'Improve Your Business with Excellent Customer Service' under My Courses.

## 3

### Download materials

Slides and the Learner Guide — your open-book references for the assessment.

## 4

### Submit & survey

Upload your assessment answers and complete the TRAQOM survey QR here.

All course material is downloaded from the LMS/TMS portal — keep it handy: the final assessment is open book.



## SCHEDULE

# Lesson Plan — 1 Day, 9:00am–6:00pm

### Morning — LU1: needs & feedback

- **Morning (AM attendance)**
  - Welcome, introductions, learning outcomes
  - Topic 1: Understanding Customers & Service + Activity 1
  - Topic 2: Establishing Your Attitude + Activity 2
  - Tea break (15 min)
  - Topic 3: Identifying Customer Needs + Activity 3
  - Topic 4: In-Person Service + Activity 4
  - Lunch break 12:50–1:50pm

### Afternoon — LU1 channels + LU2: improvement

- **Afternoon (PM attendance)**
  - Topic 5: Phone Service + Activity 5
  - Topic 6: Email & Chat Service + Activity 6
  - Tea break (15 min)
  - Topic 7: Return Business from Feedback + Activity 7
  - Topic 8: Recovering Difficult Customers + Activity 8
  - Topic 9: When to Escalate + Activity 9
  - TRAQOM · Briefing · Assessment (OQ 30 min + RP 30 min)

8 hours: 7 h classroom facilitation + 1 h assessment · 1-hour lunch · tea breaks counted within training time.

# Skills Framework — Customer Service Innovation Management

| TSC element             | Detail                                                                           |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>TSC Title / Code</b> | Customer Service Innovation Management · EPW-CEX-3034-1.1                        |
| <b>Ability A1</b>       | Carry out collection of customer feedback on service                             |
| <b>Ability A2</b>       | Determine customer's needs and expectations in relation to products and services |
| <b>Ability A3</b>       | Determine areas of improvement as per customer feedback                          |
| <b>Knowledge K1</b>     | Principles of effective communication                                            |
| <b>Knowledge K2</b>     | Customer feedback channels                                                       |
| <b>Knowledge K3</b>     | Operation and process personnel feedback channels                                |

Every topic, activity and assessment item in this course maps to these TSC abilities and knowledge factors.

BY THE END OF THIS COURSE

# Learning Outcomes

1

## LO1

Collect and analyse customer feedback to assess needs and expectations using effective communication principles.

2

## LO2

Identify and recommend areas for improvement based on customer feedback and operational insights.

# Course Outline — Two Learning Units, Nine Topics

## Morning

- **LU1 — Customer's Needs and Feedback (LO1)**
  - T1 Understanding Customers & Customer Service
  - T2 Establishing Your Service Attitude
  - T3 Identifying and Addressing Customer Needs
  - T4 In-Person Customer Service
  - T5 Customer Service Over the Phone
  - T6 Customer Service via Email and Chat

## Afternoon

- **LU2 — Improving Needs Based on Feedback (LO2)**
  - T7 Generating Return Business from Feedback
  - T8 Recovering Difficult Customers
  - T9 Understanding When to Escalate
- **9 real-world case-study activities**
  - Every topic is practised on a realistic Singapore scenario
  - Role plays mirror the Role Play assessment format

# Briefing for Assessment

1

## Clear your workspace

Phones and materials under the table or on the floor.

2

## No photos or recording

Assessment scripts must not be photographed or copied.

3

## No discussion

The assessment is individual, from the moment it starts.

4

## Black or blue pen only

For hard-copy scripts. No pencil.

5

## No correction fluid or tape

Strike through a mistake cleanly and write beside it.

6

## Scripts collected on time

When time is up, pens down and hand the script over.

Open book means the slides, the Learner Guide and approved materials only — not the internet, and not each other.

# Final Assessment

1

## Oral Questioning (OQ) — 30 min

3 open-ended questions covering K1, K2 and K3. Individual, open book.

2

## Role Play (RP) — 30 min

2 simulated customer interactions covering A1, A2 and A3. Individual, open book.

3

## Open book

Slides, Learner Guide and approved materials only.

4

## Both must be Competent

You must be assessed Competent in BOTH instruments to pass.

5

## 75% attendance required

Attendance and a Competent result are both needed for funding.

6

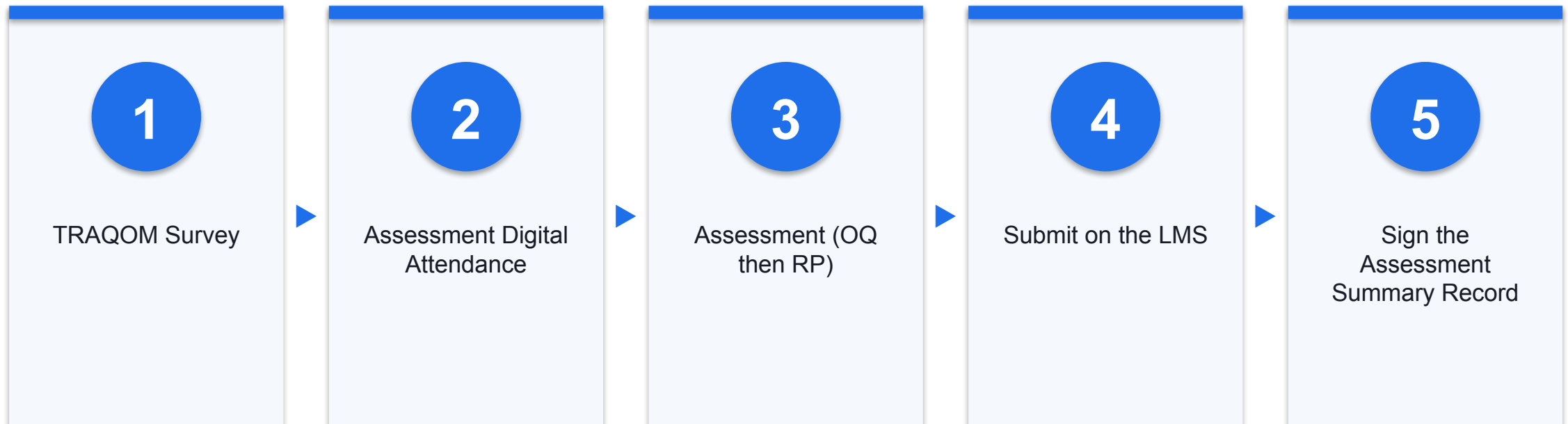
## Appeals available

You may appeal if you disagree with the assessment outcome.

Oral Clarification of up to 10 minutes may be conducted 1:1 to close minor performance gaps — this is not counted in the assessment duration.

# Assessment Flow

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## WHY THIS COURSE MATTERS

# Service is not a department.

It is every interaction a customer has with your business — before, during and after the sale.



LEARNING UNIT 1

# Customer's Needs and Feedback

LO1 · Collect and analyse customer feedback to assess needs and expectations

TOPIC 01

# Understanding Customers & Customer Service

Who customers are · what service is · who provides it · the service-profit chain

# Topic 1 — Key Concepts

1

## Service is every interaction

Customer service is the whole of the support a customer receives before, during and after a purchase — not just the complaint desk.

2

## External and internal customers

External customers buy from you; internal customers are colleagues who depend on your output. Both are served.

3

## Service quality is a chain

Internal support enables frontline delivery, which shapes customer experience, which drives loyalty and revenue.

4

## Service is a growth centre

Help Scout: great service is a growth centre, not a cost centre — retention, referral and lifetime value all flow from it.

5

## The cost of getting it wrong

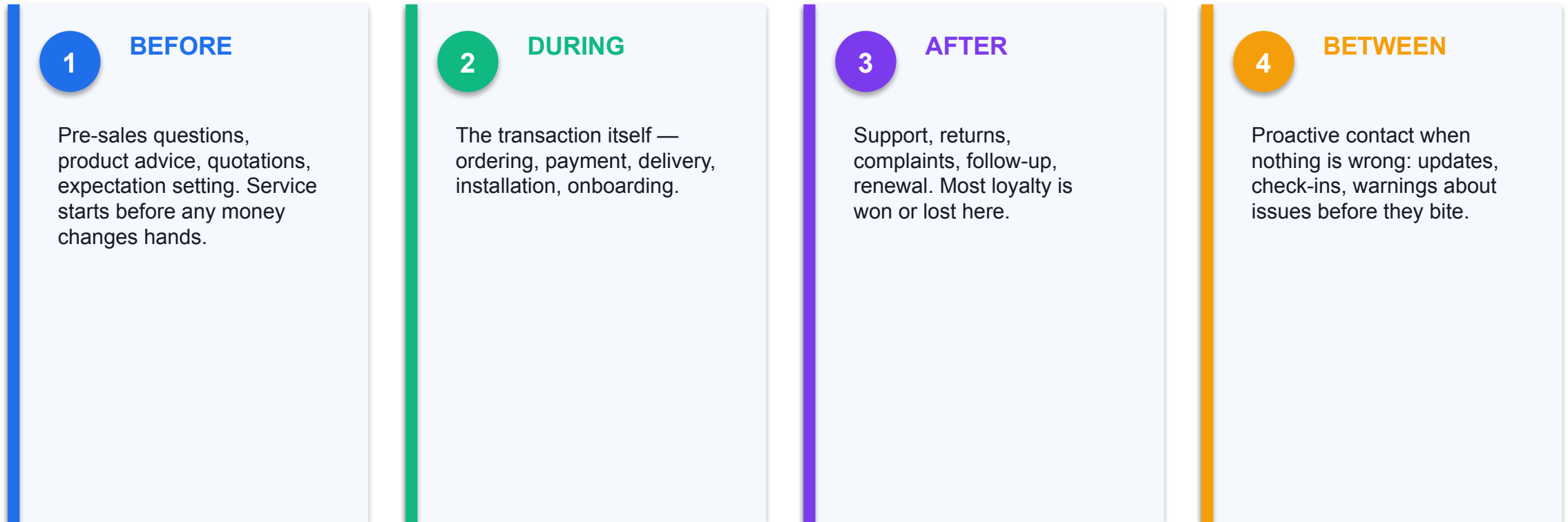
86% of customers stop buying after poor experiences; US firms lose over US\$62 billion a year to bad service (Help Scout).

6

## Four principles of good service

Help Scout: service must be personalised, competent, convenient and proactive — all four, or the experience breaks.

# What Customer Service Actually Covers



Most organisations resource the middle column well and the last two poorly — which is precisely where retention is decided.

# External and Internal Customers

## EXTERNAL CUSTOMERS

- Buy your product or service and generate revenue.
- Judge you on the outcome AND on how they were treated.
- Can leave — and mostly leave silently, without complaining.
- Their experience is shaped by people they never meet.

## INTERNAL CUSTOMERS

- Colleagues and departments who depend on your output.
- Cannot leave — so dissatisfaction shows up as friction, not churn.
- Enable (or block) the frontline's ability to serve.
- Treated as customers, they make external service possible.

The rule that runs through this whole course: excellent external service always begins with strong internal service.

# How Service Quality Actually Flows



### THE RULE

Excellent external service always begins with strong internal service. A break in any link becomes visible at the frontline — but it is rarely caused there.

### Support enables delivery

IT, HR and operations decide what the frontline is even able to offer.

### Delivery shapes perception

The customer only ever sees the last link — so that is where blame lands.

### Perception drives loyalty

Loyalty and referral are downstream of experience, not of product quality alone.

### Break one link, break the chain

A failure anywhere upstream surfaces as a frontline service failure.

# The Four Principles of Good Service

1

## PERSONALISED

A human interaction that shows the organisation actually cares about this specific customer.

2

## COMPETENT

Strong product knowledge PLUS the authority to act on it. Knowledge without authority frustrates everyone.

3

## CONVENIENT

Available on the channel the customer prefers, not the one cheapest for you.

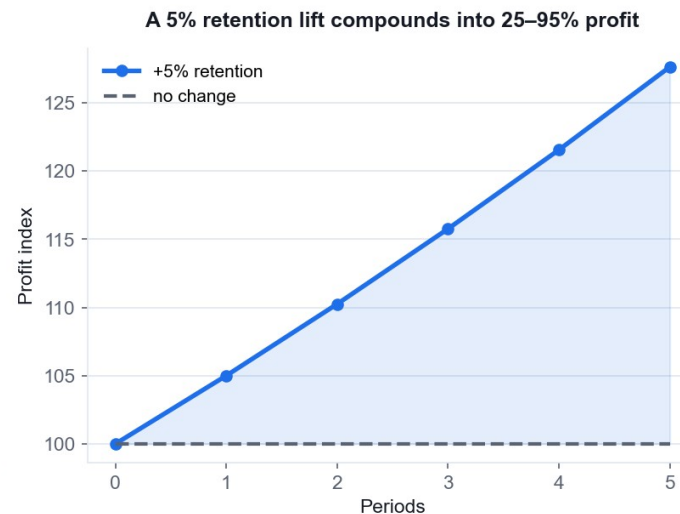
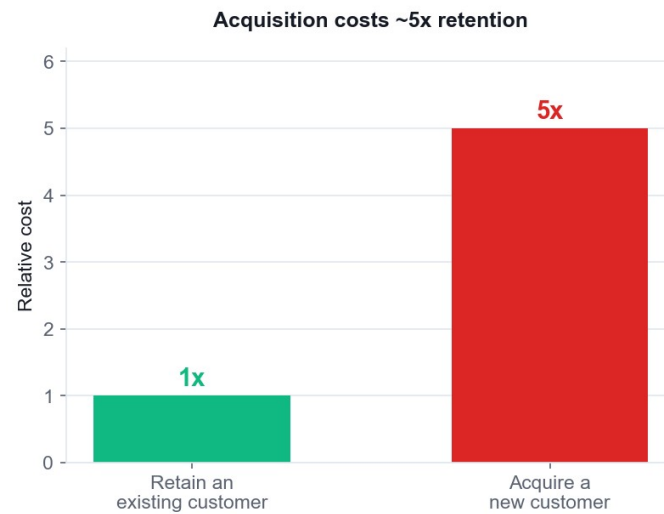
4

## PROACTIVE

You reach out about delays and issues before the customer has to ask.

All four must hold. Personalised but incompetent is charming and useless; competent but inconvenient still loses the customer.

# The Business Case for Service



## Acquisition costs ~5x

Winning a replacement customer costs far more than keeping the one you have.

## Retention compounds

A 5% retention improvement can move profit by 25–95% over time.

## Poor service drives churn

86% of customers stop buying after poor experiences.

## Service is a growth centre

Not a cost centre — the framing decides whether it gets resourced.



# Who Delivers Customer Service

1

## Frontline staff

The first — often only — human contact. They carry the entire perception.

2

## Support and back office

Never seen by the customer, but they determine what the frontline can promise.

3

## Managers and leaders

Set the standards, the metrics and the amount of authority the frontline has.

4

## Self-service systems

FAQ, chatbots, portals — service delivered without a person, and judged just as harshly.

5

## Every other department

Product, finance, logistics — each creates or removes friction the customer feels.

6

## The customer themselves

Reviews, referrals and word of mouth extend your service reputation beyond your control.

# Activity 1 — Mapping the Service Chain at a Singapore Bank Branch

## THE SCENARIO

OCBC-style retail branch, Tampines. Mdm Rohani, 68, comes in to reactivate a dormant savings account so her CPF payout can be credited. The queue ticket says 12 minutes; she waits 47. At the counter, the teller, Wei Ming, finds the reactivation needs a signature-verification form that Operations must approve. Operations is understaffed and quotes 3 working days. Wei Ming has no authority to expedite and no way to see the Operations queue. Mdm Rohani has already made two trips. She says loudly that she will move her account to another bank, and other customers in the queue are listening.

Behind the counter: the branch manager has a service-level dashboard showing counter wait times but not back-office turnaround. Operations measures forms processed per day, not customer trips avoided. The digital team launched an app-based reactivation two months ago that nobody told the branch about.

**FORMAT** Case Study + Peer Sharing

**ROLES** Groups of 4–5. Each group maps the chain; one member presents.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 1 · Activities folder: activities/activity-01/

# Activity 1 — Discussion Questions

1

Who are the EXTERNAL customers in this case, and who are the INTERNAL customers? List every one.

2

Draw the service chain from Mdm Rohani's need to the outcome she actually got. Where exactly did it break?

3

Wei Ming was polite and followed procedure, and the customer still left angry. Whose service failure is this?

4

Operations measures 'forms processed per day'. What behaviour does that metric produce, and what does it miss?

5

The app-based reactivation existed but the branch did not know. What internal service failure does that reveal?

6

Name one change per link in the chain that would have prevented this outcome.

20 minutes · Groups of 4–5. Each group maps the chain; one member presents.

# Activity 1 — Debrief

The frontline is where the failure BECOMES VISIBLE, not where it is caused. Wei Ming did nothing wrong — he was set up to fail by the links behind him.

Internal customers here: Wei Ming is Operations' customer; the branch is the digital team's customer; Operations is the branch manager's customer. Every one of those relationships failed.

'Forms processed per day' optimises throughput, not resolution. It is blind to Mdm Rohani's THREE trips — the metric would look healthy while the customer churns.

The undisclosed app feature is a pure internal-communication failure. A capability the frontline does not know about does not exist.

Expected fixes: give the teller visibility of the Operations queue; give SOMEONE authority to expedite; measure customer trips not forms; brief the branch on every new digital capability.

Link back to Topic 1: excellent external service always begins with strong internal service. This case is the proof.

**TEST IT** Your map names at least 3 internal customers, marks at least 3 broken links, and each fix is a specific action with an owner.

TOPIC 02

# Establishing Your Service Attitude

Appearance · the power of a smile · staying energised · staying positive · positive language

## Topic 2 — Key Concepts

1

### Attitude is visible instantly

First impressions form in 4–7 seconds; roughly 55% of that impression comes from appearance and body language.

2

### Emotions are contagious

Your mood transfers to the customer. A genuine smile measurably raises trust and how welcome a guest feels.

3

### Positive language reframes limits

'That's back-ordered' becomes 'That's available next month — I can reserve it now.' Same fact, different outcome.

4

### Energy must be managed

Service quality decays with fatigue. Structured micro-breaks and shift resets protect the last customer of the day.

5

### Resilience is a trained skill

Zendesk lists resilience as core: absorbing criticism without letting it degrade the next interaction.

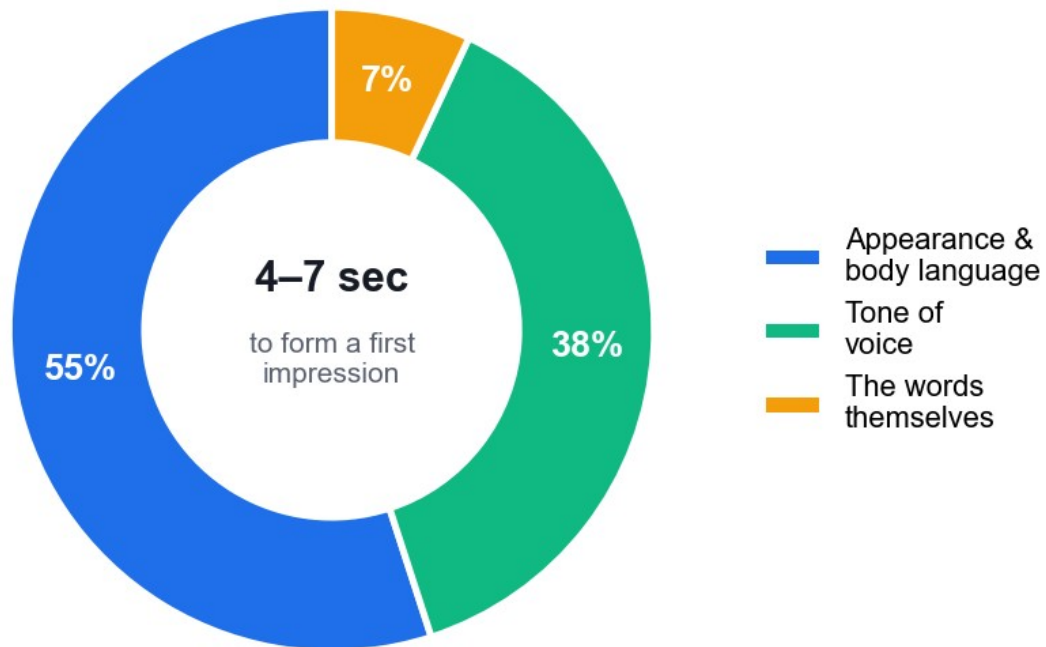
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### Professionalism is the baseline

Respectful tone, accuracy and appropriate boundaries held consistently — regardless of how the customer behaves.

# First Impressions Form Before You Speak

Your attitude is visible before you speak



## 4–7 seconds

The window in which the customer decides how this is going to go.

## 55% is what they see

Grooming, posture, expression — visible before a word is exchanged.

## 38% is how you sound

Tone, pace and warmth carry more than the words themselves.

## 7% is what you say

Correct words delivered badly still read as bad service.

# The Four Pillars of Service Attitude

## 1 APPEARANCE

Professional grooming signals competence and respect. It is the baseline expectation in Singapore hospitality and retail.

## 2 THE SMILE

A genuine smile measurably raises trust. A forced one is detected instantly and costs more than none.

## 3 ENERGY

Service quality decays with fatigue. Managed breaks protect the last customer of the day.

## 4 POSITIVITY

Reframe the limit into what IS possible. Do not take the complaint personally.

Attitude is not a personality trait you either have or lack — every one of these four pillars is a trainable, repeatable behaviour.



## Positive Language — Same Facts, Opposite Outcome

### NEGATIVE FRAMING

- "That product is back-ordered and unavailable."
- "I don't know."
- "You have to log out first."
- "That's not our policy."
- "You'll have to pay for that yourself."
- "There's nothing I can do."

### POSITIVE FRAMING

- "That's available next month — I can reserve it now."
- "Let me find out for you."
- "Logging out should fix that quickly!"
- "Here's what I can do for you."
- "I can book that for you at the member rate."
- "Let me get someone who can authorise that."

Positive language does not mean saying yes. It means directing the customer to what IS available — with the same underlying answer.

# Managing Yourself Across a Shift

1

## Emotional contagion

Your mood transfers to the customer within seconds — and theirs to you.

2

## Reset between customers

One breath and a deliberate posture reset stops case 11 inheriting case 10's frustration.

3

## Micro-breaks work

Short structured breaks measurably protect service quality later in the shift.

4

## Depersonalise the complaint

They are angry at the situation, at the company, at their day — not at you.

5

## Resilience is trainable

Absorb criticism, extract the useful part, discard the rest, start clean.

6

## Know your own tells

Flat tone, short answers, no eye contact — learn to catch your own fatigue signals.

## Activity 2 — Attitude and Positive Language at a Changi Airport Service Counter

### THE SCENARIO

Changi Airport Terminal 3, airline transfer desk, 11:40pm. Mr Krishnan and his two children (aged 4 and 7) have missed their connecting flight to Chennai because the inbound flight was delayed by weather. The next available flight is 14 hours away. Company policy for weather delays: no hotel accommodation, no meal vouchers, rebooking only. The children are crying. Mr Krishnan has been queueing for 35 minutes and is the eleventh passenger you have seen with the same problem tonight. You are 90 minutes past the end of your shift.

What you CAN do: rebook him on the 1:50pm flight; give him lounge access at your discretion; provide a transit hotel booking form at his own cost; escalate to the duty manager for a goodwill exception.

**FORMAT** Role Play + Peer Sharing

**ROLES** Pairs. Role A = Service Officer, Role B = Mr Krishnan. Swap after the first round. Observers score.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 2 · Activities folder: activities/activity-02/

## Activity 2 — Discussion Questions

1

Rewrite each phrase in positive language: 'We don't cover weather delays.' / 'There's nothing I can do.' / 'You'll have to pay for that yourself.' / 'That's not our policy.' / 'I don't know.'

2

You are 90 minutes past your shift end and this is the eleventh identical case. How does that show up in your body language and voice, even when your words are correct?

3

The answer to 'will you pay for my hotel?' is genuinely no. How do you say no and still leave the customer feeling served?

4

What can you offer that costs the company little but changes how Mr Krishnan experiences this? Name three things.

5

At what point, if any, would you escalate to the duty manager — and what would you say to Mr Krishnan as you do it?

6

The two crying children are not your customer, but they change the interaction. How?

15 minutes · Pairs. Role A = Service Officer, Role B = Mr Krishnan. Swap after the first round. Observers score.

## Activity 2 — Debrief

Positive language does not mean saying yes. It means directing the customer to what IS available: 'I can get you on the 1:50pm and into the lounge now' beats 'we don't cover weather delays' with the same underlying answer.

'I don't know' becomes 'let me find out' — the second is the same information plus ownership.

Fatigue leaks through the non-verbal channel first. Words stay professional long after tone and posture have given up. Observers should watch for flat tone, no eye contact, and a sigh before speaking.

The three low-cost offers most groups find: lounge access (comfort for the kids), a proactive rebooking done before he asks, and a printed confirmation so he does not have to re-explain at the next desk.

Acknowledge the children explicitly — the customer's stress is mostly about them. Serving the parent means noticing the kids.

Escalation here is not defeat: naming the duty manager and saying 'I want to ask if we can make an exception for you' shows the customer you are on their side of the counter.

**TEST IT** You delivered a genuine 'no' inside 2 minutes, offered at least two alternatives unprompted, and your partner reports feeling served rather than dismissed.

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# Tea Break

15 minutes

TOPIC 03

# Identifying and Addressing Customer Needs

Active listening · questioning · the four levels of need · going the extra mile

## Topic 3 — Key Concepts

1

### Needs are functional and emotional

The product must work (functional) and the customer must feel valued (emotional). Missing either loses the customer.

2

### Active listening is the core skill

Attend fully, paraphrase back, read the cues, then confirm. Only 17% of customers believe businesses actually listen (Tidio).

3

### Ask before you prescribe

Open questions surface the real need; closed questions confirm it. Diagnosing before solving prevents the wrong fix.

4

### Attentiveness reads the unsaid

Repeated 'I couldn't find it' across customers is a UX defect report, not a series of individual questions.

5

### Four levels of addressing needs

Understand the problem → meet the basic need → think outside the box → go the extra mile.

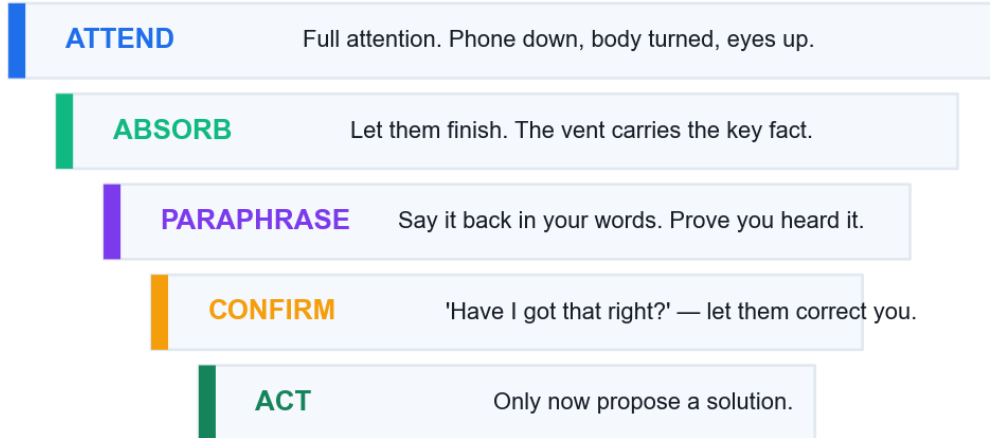
6

### Personalisation drives loyalty

Use history and context; 35% would rather deal with an AI than repeat themselves to a human (Salesforce).



# Active Listening — Making Listening Visible



## Attend

Full attention. Phone down, body turned, eyes up.  
Half-attention is detected instantly.

## Absorb

Let them finish. The vent almost always contains the key fact.

## Paraphrase

Say it back in your own words — this is what makes listening visible.

## Confirm, then act

'Have I got that right?' Only after a yes do you propose a solution.

Only 17% of customers believe businesses actually listen to them. Paraphrasing is what makes listening visible.

Only 17% of customers believe businesses actually listen to them — paraphrasing is the cheapest way to be in the other 83%.

# Questioning — Open to Explore, Closed to Confirm

## CLOSED QUESTIONS (confirm)

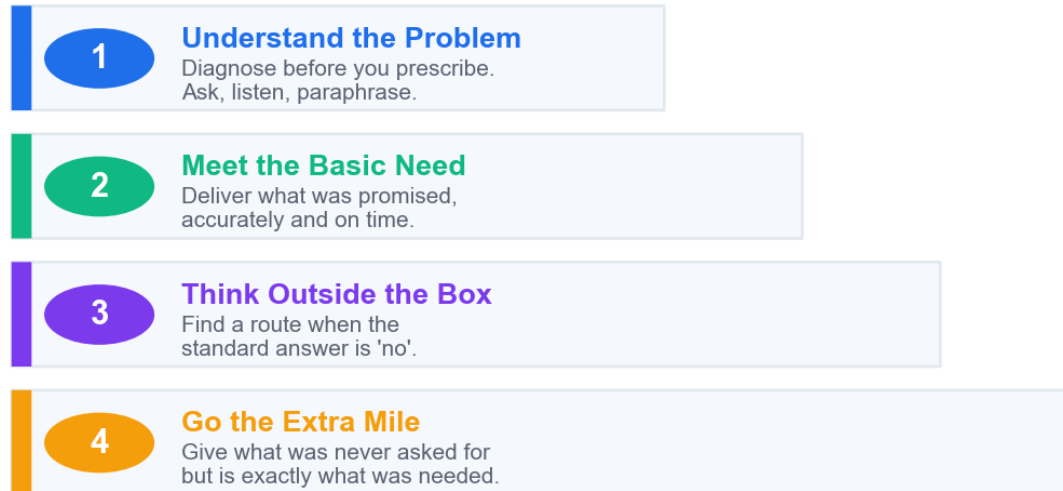
- "Is the account under your name?"
- "Did you receive the confirmation email?"
- "Would Tuesday work for delivery?"
- Use to: pin down facts, confirm, close a decision.
- Risk: asking these first makes it an interrogation.

## OPEN QUESTIONS (explore)

- "Walk me through what happened."
- "What were you expecting to see?"
- "How is this affecting your work?"
- Use to: surface the real need and the emotion behind it.
- Rule: if it can be answered yes/no, rewrite it.

Open first to understand, closed second to confirm. Reversing the order is the most common needs-identification failure.

# The Four Levels of Addressing Customer Needs



Each level is only available once the level below it is solid.

## 1 · Understand

Diagnose the actual problem before offering any solution.

## 2 · Meet the basic need

Deliver what was promised, accurately and on time.  
Non-negotiable.

## 3 · Outside the box

Find a route when the standard answer is 'no'.

## 4 · The extra mile

Give what was never asked for but was exactly what was needed.

Level 4 delivered while level 2 is failing reads as a distraction — you cannot skip the rungs.

# What They Said vs What They Need

## WHAT THE CUSTOMER SAID

"Uploads are painfully slow."  
"The reports are useless."  
"Support took 4 days to reply."  
"Competitors offer more for less."

## WHAT THE CUSTOMER NEEDS

A plan that fits a 50-person firm  
Cost-per-project roll-up for the MD  
Confidence the vendor is reliable  
A defensible business case —  
by end of month



**The complaints are symptoms. The last line of the email is the actual brief.  
Solve only the left column and you still lose the account.**

## Complaints are symptoms

The stated problem is where they started, not where the need lives.

## Functional vs emotional

The product must work AND the customer must feel valued.

## Listen for the deadline

The real brief is often the last sentence, not the first.

## Attentiveness reads patterns

The same complaint from many customers is a defect report.

# Activity 3 — Diagnosing Customer Needs at a Growing SME — TechNova Account Review

## THE SCENARIO

TechNova Solutions (Singapore) supplies a cloud project-management platform. Mr Daniel Lim is Operations Director at Horizon Builders Pte Ltd, a Woodlands-based construction firm and a customer for 6 years. Horizon has grown from 12 to 50 employees. Daniel emails: 'Uploads are painfully slow, the reports are useless for what we need, and it took your support team 4 days to answer my last ticket. Competitors are offering us more for less. I need to justify this renewal to my MD by end of month.'

What the account record shows: Horizon is on Team Pro (a 15-seat plan) with 50 users sharing logins. Upload slowness correlates with 200MB+ site photo batches — the plan caps concurrent uploads. The reporting Daniel wants (cost-per-project roll-up) exists in the Enterprise tier. The 4-day ticket was logged during the Chinese New Year holiday period. Daniel has never had a formal account review in 6 years.

**FORMAT** Case Study + Role Play

**ROLES** Pairs. Role A = TechNova Account Manager, Role B = Daniel Lim. Assessor-style observer optional.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 3 · Activities folder: activities/activity-03/

## Activity 3 — Discussion Questions

- 1 Separate what Daniel SAID from what Daniel NEEDS. Write two columns. They are not the same list.
- 2 Identify Daniel's FUNCTIONAL needs and his EMOTIONAL needs. Which one is driving the email's tone?
- 3 'I need to justify this renewal to my MD by end of month.' What does this sentence tell you that the complaints do not?
- 4 Map your findings to the four levels: understand the problem / meet basic needs / think outside the box / go the extra mile. What sits at each level?
- 5 Horizon has 50 users on a 15-seat plan. This is a contract breach AND the cause of the slowness. How do you raise it without turning a save into a fight?
- 6 Six years, no account review. What does that reveal about TechNova's own service process — and what should change?

20 minutes · Pairs. Role A = TechNova Account Manager, Role B = Daniel Lim. Assessor-style observer optional.

## Activity 3 — Debrief

Said vs needed: he SAYS slow uploads, useless reports, slow support. He NEEDS a defensible business case for his MD by month end. Solve only the first three and you still lose the account.

The emotional need is dominant: Daniel is exposed in front of his MD. The functional fixes are the evidence he needs to not look foolish for having stayed 6 years.

The last sentence is the actual brief. Everything before it is symptoms. Learners who spot this are doing genuine needs identification rather than complaint triage.

Four levels — understand: the plan no longer fits a 50-person firm. Basic: fix the upload cap and the ticket SLA. Outside the box: the seat overage is leverage for a migration, not a penalty. Extra mile: build the cost-per-project report FOR his MD deck.

The 15-seat breach must be raised as a discovery, not an accusation: 'your growth has outrun the plan we sold you six years ago — that's on us for not reviewing it.'

The real service failure is TechNova's: no account review in 6 years means nobody was listening until the customer shouted. The process fix is a scheduled review cadence — this is a Topic 7 closed-loop point arriving early.

**TEST IT** Your needs analysis has at least one emotional need identified, all four levels populated, and your role-play partner confirms you surfaced the MD deadline as the real brief.

TOPIC 04

# In-Person Customer Service

Walk-ins and at-your-desk requests · body language · advantages and limits of face-to-face



## Topic 4 — Key Concepts

1

### Face-to-face is highest bandwidth

Tone, posture, expression and timing all carry meaning that text channels strip away.

2

### Immediate feedback loop

Misunderstandings surface and are corrected within seconds — the strongest advantage over email or chat.

3

### Body language you control

Open posture, ~70% eye contact, a slight forward lean and subtle mirroring build rapport without a word.

4

### Signals that cost you trust

Crossed arms, glancing at a phone, turning away or a fixed forced smile all read as disengagement.

5

### Acknowledge within seconds

Greet a walk-in within about 3 seconds even when occupied; being seen matters before being served.

6

### The limits of in-person

No automatic record, queueing pressure and scheduling conflicts — document afterwards or it never happened.

# In-Person Service — Strengths and Limits

## THE LIMITATIONS

- No automatic record — if you don't write it down, it didn't happen.
- Queueing pressure: everyone waiting sees how long you take.
- You can only serve one person at a time.
- Scheduling conflicts and walk-in unpredictability.
- Harder to escalate discreetly with an audience present.

## THE ADVANTAGES

- Immediate feedback — misunderstandings die in seconds.
- Full non-verbal bandwidth: posture, expression, timing.
- Strongest channel for building trust and rapport.
- Easiest channel on which to de-escalate genuine anger.
- You can show, demonstrate and hand over physically.

The channel's great weakness is memory: always follow a face-to-face resolution with a written summary.

# Body Language You Control

1

## POSTURE

Open and uncrossed, with a slight forward lean. Signals engagement and honesty.

2

## EYE CONTACT

Around 70% of the time. Constant staring intimidates; avoidance reads as dishonesty.

3

## MIRRORING

Subtly match their pace and energy. Builds rapport below conscious awareness.

4

## THE SMILE

Genuine and brief at greeting. It sets the emotional tone for everything after.

Signals that cost you trust: crossed arms, glancing at your phone, turning your torso away, or a fixed forced smile.

## THE PARK AND RETURN METHOD

# Handling a Walk-In While You Are Already Busy

1

### Acknowledge within 3 seconds

Eye contact, a raised hand, 'I'll be right with you.' Being SEEN precedes being served.

2

### Give a realistic wait

'About two minutes' buys you two minutes. A vague wait buys you nothing.

3

### Protect the active customer

The person you are serving keeps priority — say so openly so the queue hears the rule.

4

### Note your park point

Record where you stopped so you resume without making anyone repeat themselves.

5

### Return and reference

Open with what they told you: 'you mentioned a cracked screen' proves you were listening.

6

### Close with next steps

Summarise what happens now, so they leave with certainty rather than hope.

Making a customer re-explain their problem is the single failure this method exists to prevent.

# Activity 4 — The Walk-In Interruption — Retail Service Counter, Bugis

## THE SCENARIO

A telco retail store at Bugis Junction, Saturday 2pm. You are at the service counter finishing a SIM registration for a customer who is standing beside you waiting for the confirmation SMS. The store phone rings. At the same moment, Ms Chen walks up to your counter holding a phone with a cracked screen and says 'Excuse me, I just need a quick answer' — she has been in the store for 20 minutes looking for someone. Two more customers are visibly waiting behind her.

You cannot serve three people at once. Everything you do in the next 15 seconds is visible to all of them.

**FORMAT** Role Play

**ROLES** Groups of 4. Role A = Service Officer, B = SIM customer, C = Ms Chen, D = observer/phone caller.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 4 · Activities folder: activities/activity-04/

## Activity 4 — Discussion Questions

1

In the first 15 seconds, what do you do — and in what order? Be specific about words, eyes and hands.

2

Ms Chen says 'I just need a quick answer'. Is it ever actually quick? What is the risk of treating it as quick?

3

How do you acknowledge Ms Chen without abandoning the customer already at your counter?

4

The phone is ringing and no one else can take it. What do you do, and what does the customer in front of you see you do?

5

What body language keeps all three parties feeling attended to while you can only serve one?

6

What is the 'park and return' method, and where exactly would you use it here?

## Activity 4 — Debrief

Order matters: eye contact + a raised hand + 'I'll be right with you, about two minutes' to Ms Chen takes 3 seconds and buys 2 minutes. Being SEEN precedes being served.

'Quick answer' is almost never quick — a cracked screen means warranty status, purchase date, insurance and a repair booking. Treating it as quick means starting something you cannot finish and now failing two customers.

The customer in front of you keeps priority. State that openly to the room: it reassures the person you are serving AND tells the queue there is a fair rule.

The phone: let it go to the queue or answer with 'may I take your number and call you back in five minutes?' Never leave a physical customer standing while you have a full phone conversation — the person present outranks the person calling.

Body language: keep your torso oriented to the counter customer, turn only your head to Ms Chen, and use an open palm rather than a pointed finger. Turning your whole body away is the abandonment signal.

Park and return: note where you were in the SIM registration before you turn away, so you resume without asking the first customer to repeat anything. Making a customer re-explain is the failure this method exists to prevent.

**TEST IT** You acknowledged the walk-in within 5 seconds, no customer was asked to repeat themselves, and the observer confirms you never fully turned away from the customer you were actively serving.

---

# Lunch Break

12:50pm – 1:50pm



TOPIC 05

# Customer Service Over the Phone

Telephone etiquette · voice as the whole channel · hold and transfer · call structure

## Topic 5 — Key Concepts

1

### **Voice carries everything**

With no visual channel, tone, pace and warmth do all the work that body language does in person.

2

### **Phone still dominates complex issues**

When an issue needs back-and-forth clarification, customers still reach for the phone over text channels.

3

### **Etiquette is measurable**

Answer within three rings, smile while speaking, never interrupt, avoid jargon, always close with next steps.

4

### **Hold is a permission, not an action**

Ask before holding, explain why, give a time, thank them on return — otherwise it reads as being dumped.

5

### **Paraphrase to prove you listened**

'So the order was due Monday and hasn't arrived' converts a vent into a defined, solvable problem.

6

### **Scripts guide, they don't speak**

Rigid scripts sound robotic. Use them as a spine and personalise the words to the caller in front of you.

# The Professional Call — Six Stages



The four-part hold is where most calls are lost: ask permission · state the reason · give a duration · thank them on return.

## Greet and listen

Within three rings, smile first, then let them finish without interruption.

## Paraphrase and confirm

Say the whole issue back. Wait for their yes before moving on.

## Hold properly

Ask, explain, give a duration, thank them on return. All four, every time.

## Resolve and close

Options with a recommendation, then a time, an owner and a reference number.

# Telephone Service — What Loses and Wins Calls

## WHAT LOSES THE CALL

- Interrupting to defend the company mid-vent.
- Silent hold with no reason and no time given.
- Reading a rigid script — it sounds robotic instantly.
- Jargon and internal system names.
- Vague closes: 'we'll look into it and get back to you.'
- Transferring without explaining or introducing.

## WHAT WINS THE CALL

- Letting the first 30–45 seconds run — the key fact is in there.
- Smiling before you speak — it changes your voice audibly.
- Using their name naturally, two or three times.
- Paraphrasing before proposing anything.
- A specific time, a named owner and a reference number.
- One proactive follow-up call, made whether or not it worked.

With no visual channel, tone and pace do all the work that posture and expression do in person.

## WHERE MOST CALLS ARE LOST

# Placing a Customer on Hold — the Four Parts

1

### Ask permission

'May I put you on hold for a moment?' — then actually wait for the answer.

2

### State the reason

'...while I get my supervisor to authorise the re-route.' Reason converts waiting into progress.

3

### Give a realistic duration

'About three minutes.' Then beat it, or come back and re-contract.

4

### Thank them on return

'Thank you for waiting.' Missing this one part makes the whole hold feel like being dumped.

A hold is a permission you are granted, not an action you perform on the customer.

## Activity 5 — The Angry Delivery Call — Logistics Hotline

### THE SCENARIO

You work the customer hotline for a Singapore last-mile logistics firm. Mr Faisal calls at 4:15pm. His package — a replacement CPAP machine part his father needs — was due Monday. It is now Thursday. Tracking has said 'out for delivery' for three days. He has called twice before; both times he was told 'it will be delivered today'. He opens the call at volume: 'I've been lied to twice. Don't tell me it's out for delivery. Where is my package?'

What you find while he is talking: the parcel was mis-sorted to the Jurong hub on Monday, scanned back out Wednesday, and is genuinely on a van today — but the van's route ends at 9pm and he is stop 61 of 68. You can request a priority re-route (needs hub supervisor approval, ~10 minutes) or offer next-morning guaranteed delivery before 10am.

**FORMAT** Role Play

**ROLES** Pairs, seated back to back so there is no visual channel. A = Hotline Officer, B = Mr Faisal.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 5 · Activities folder: activities/activity-05/

## Activity 5 — Discussion Questions

1

Mr Faisal opens by shouting. What are your first words, and how long do you let him talk before you speak?

2

He says 'I've been lied to twice.' Is that true? How do you respond to it without blaming a colleague or defending the company?

3

Write the exact sentence you would use to paraphrase his issue back to him.

4

You need 10 minutes to get supervisor approval. How do you place him on hold correctly — what four things must you say?

5

You have two options (priority re-route vs guaranteed next morning). Do you choose for him or offer both? Why?

6

Why does the CPAP detail change how you handle this call, and what would you have missed if you had interrupted him?

15 minutes · Pairs, seated back to back so there is no visual channel. A = Hotline Officer, B = Mr Faisal.

## Activity 5 — Debrief

Let him finish. The first 30–45 seconds are venting and contain the CPAP detail — the single most important fact in the call. An officer who interrupts to defend the tracking system never learns why this parcel matters.

'I've been lied to twice' — do not defend and do not blame. 'You were given a delivery promise twice and it did not happen. That's on us.' Acknowledging the customer's EXPERIENCE is not admitting to a lie.

Good paraphrase: 'So your father's CPAP part was promised Monday, you've called twice, been told it's out for delivery each time, and four days on you still have nothing.' Naming the father is what proves you listened.

Correct hold has four parts: ask permission, state the reason, give a realistic duration, thank them on return. Missing any one of these makes the hold feel like being dumped.

Offer both options with a recommendation. The CPAP context makes guaranteed 10am delivery likely better than stop 61 at 9pm — but it is his father and his call. Choosing FOR the customer removes the one piece of control he still has.

This call is a Topic 7 case in disguise: the mis-sort is the fault, but the SERVICE failure is two false promises. Note it for the feedback loop — the fix is not promising a date the system cannot see.

**TEST IT** You did not interrupt during the opening vent, your paraphrase included the father/CPAP detail, your hold had all four elements, and your close named a specific time and owner.



TOPIC 06

# Customer Service via Email and Chat

Netiquette · email structure · written tone · choosing between email and live chat

## Topic 6 — Key Concepts

1

### Writing is a service skill

'You have to log out first' and 'Logging out should fix that quickly!' carry identical information and opposite tone.

2

### Email creates the record

The written trail is the channel's real advantage: the customer can re-read it and you can prove what was agreed.

3

### Netiquette rules are not optional

No ALL CAPS, no unexplained jargon, a clear action-oriented subject line and a real signature block.

4

### A five-part email structure

Personalised greeting → acknowledge the issue → give the solution → state next steps → professional sign-off.

5

### Email vs live chat

Email suits complex, documented, attachment-bearing issues; chat suits short, real-time, single-question issues.

6

### Proofread before you send

Grammar and spelling errors read as carelessness and quietly transfer to how the customer rates your competence.

# The Anatomy of a Service Email

| Subject: Your refund for order #48213 — resolved by 26 August                                     |  |                                            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>1 GREETING</b><br>Hi Priya,                                                                    |  | Use the name. Never 'Dear Customer'.       |
| <b>2 ACKNOWLEDGE</b><br>You've waited 3 weeks and emailed twice — and the wedding is on the 30th. |  | Name the wait AND the real deadline.       |
| <b>3 SOLUTION</b><br>Your refund clears on 26 August. I've also raised an expedite request today. |  | A calendar date, not '14–21 working days'. |
| <b>4 NEXT STEPS</b><br>You don't need to chase this. I'll email you the moment it clears.         |  | Say who does what, by when.                |
| <b>5 SIGN-OFF</b><br>Sarah Tan · Customer Care · 6100 0613                                        |  | A real person and a real channel.          |

## Greeting

Their name, always. 'Dear Customer' announces that nobody read the file.

## Acknowledge

Name the wait, the prior contacts and the real deadline before anything else.

## Solution

A calendar date, not a working-day range. Ranges read as evasion.

## Next steps + sign-off

Who does what by when — signed by a real, named person.

# Netiquette — What Breaks a Service Email

## NEVER

- ALL CAPS — it reads as shouting.
- 'Dear Customer' when you have their name on file.
- Policy citations as an answer ('per T&C 7.3').
- 'Please do not email again' — you just closed their only channel.
- Unsigned 'Support Team' with no human name.
- Dead subject lines: 'RE: RE: FW: order'.

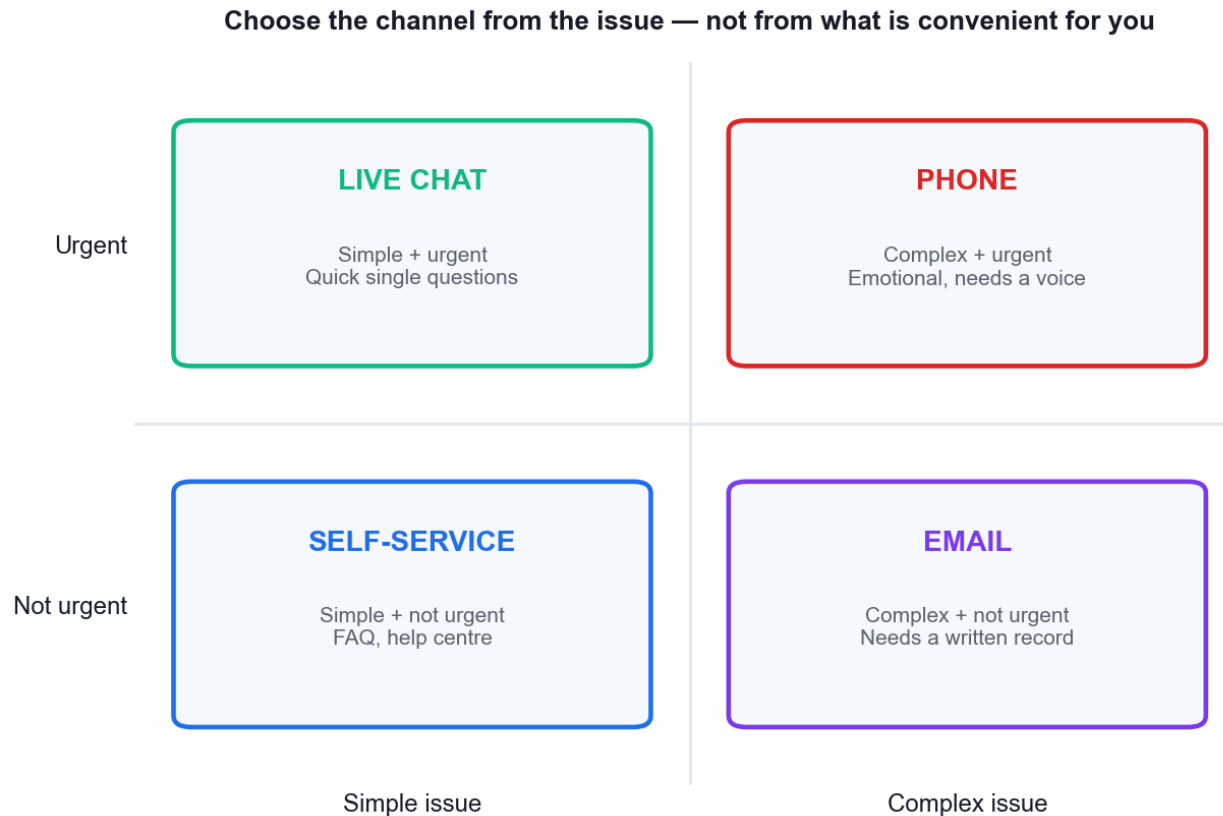
## ALWAYS

- A clear, action-oriented subject line.
- Their name, and a reference to their history with you.
- Plain language — explain the policy, don't cite it.
- A concrete date and a named owner.
- A real signature: name, role, direct contact.
- A proofread pass before you send.

An email can be 100% factually correct and still be a total service failure — accuracy is not the same as service.

## MATCH THE CHANNEL TO THE ISSUE

# Choosing the Right Channel



### Phone

Complex and urgent, or emotionally charged. Voice carries what text cannot.

### Live chat

Simple and urgent — one quick question, answered in real time.

### Email

Complex, not urgent, needs attachments and a durable written record.

### Self-service

Simple and not urgent — FAQ and help centre, available at 3am.

Best practice for a time-critical emotional issue: call first, then confirm in writing — use each channel for what it does well.

# Activity 6 — Rewriting the Refund Email — E-Commerce Support Inbox

## THE SCENARIO

A Singapore online fashion retailer. Ms Priya ordered a dress for her sister's wedding on 2 August, paid S\$189, and received the wrong size. She returned it on 8 August using the prepaid label. It is now 22 August, no refund has appeared, and the wedding is on 30 August. She has emailed twice.

The agent's reply, sent as-is:

Subject: RE: RE: FW: order

**FORMAT** Case Study + Practical Writing

**ROLES** Individually, then compare in pairs.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 6 · Activities folder: activities/activity-06/

## Activity 6 — Discussion Questions

- 1 List every netiquette failure in the agent's email. There are at least seven.
- 2 Every fact in the email is accurate. Explain how an email can be 100% correct and still be a service failure.
- 3 What is the customer's REAL deadline, and does the agent's reply acknowledge it at all?
- 4 Rewrite the email using the five-part structure: greeting → acknowledge → solution → next steps → sign-off.
- 5 'Please do not email again.' What does this sentence do to the relationship, and what should replace it?
- 6 Should this have been email, live chat or a phone call? Justify your choice against the channel-selection rule.

15 minutes · Individually, then compare in pairs.

## Activity 6 — Debrief

Netiquette failures to find: 'RE: RE: FW: order' subject line, 'Dear Customer' not her name, ALL CAPS as shouting, policy-section jargon (T&C 7.3), no apology or acknowledgement, an instruction not to make contact, an unsigned 'Support Team' with no individual name, and no next step the customer can act on.

Correct-but-failing is the key lesson: the agent answered the question the customer TYPED and ignored the question she MEANT — 'will I have this sorted before the wedding on the 30th?'

The wedding date is the real deadline and the email never mentions it. This is the same 'said vs needed' distinction from Activity 3, in writing.

A good rewrite names Priya, acknowledges two prior emails and the wedding, states the refund date with a specific day, offers something concrete (expedite request, or a replacement in the right size shipped now), and gives a named person and direct contact.

'Please do not email again' tells the customer her only channel is closed. Replace with proactive ownership: 'You don't need to chase this — I'll email you the moment it clears, and here's my direct line.'

Channel: email is right for the RECORD (money, dates, policy), but this case needed a phone call first because it is time-critical and emotional. Best practice is call, then confirm in writing — using both channels for what each does well.

**TEST IT** Your rewrite has all five parts, names the customer, acknowledges the 30 August wedding, gives a calendar date rather than a working-day range, and is signed by a named person.



---

# Tea Break

15 minutes

LEARNING UNIT 2

# Improving Customer's Needs Based on Feedback

LO2 · Identify and recommend areas for improvement from feedback and operational insight

TOPIC 07

# Generating Return Business from Feedback

Feedback channels · closing the loop · complaint handling · retention economics

## Topic 7 — Key Concepts

1

### Retention beats acquisition

Keeping a customer costs far less than winning a new one; a 5% retention lift can move profit 25–95%.

2

### Feedback channels are a portfolio

Surveys, reviews, interviews, social listening, support tickets and staff reports — each has a bias, so triangulate.

3

### CSAT, NPS and CES measure differently

CSAT rates a moment, NPS rates the relationship, CES rates the effort the customer had to spend.

4

### Most unhappy customers say nothing

Roughly 56% leave silently. The absence of complaints is not evidence of satisfaction.

5

### Closing the loop is the point

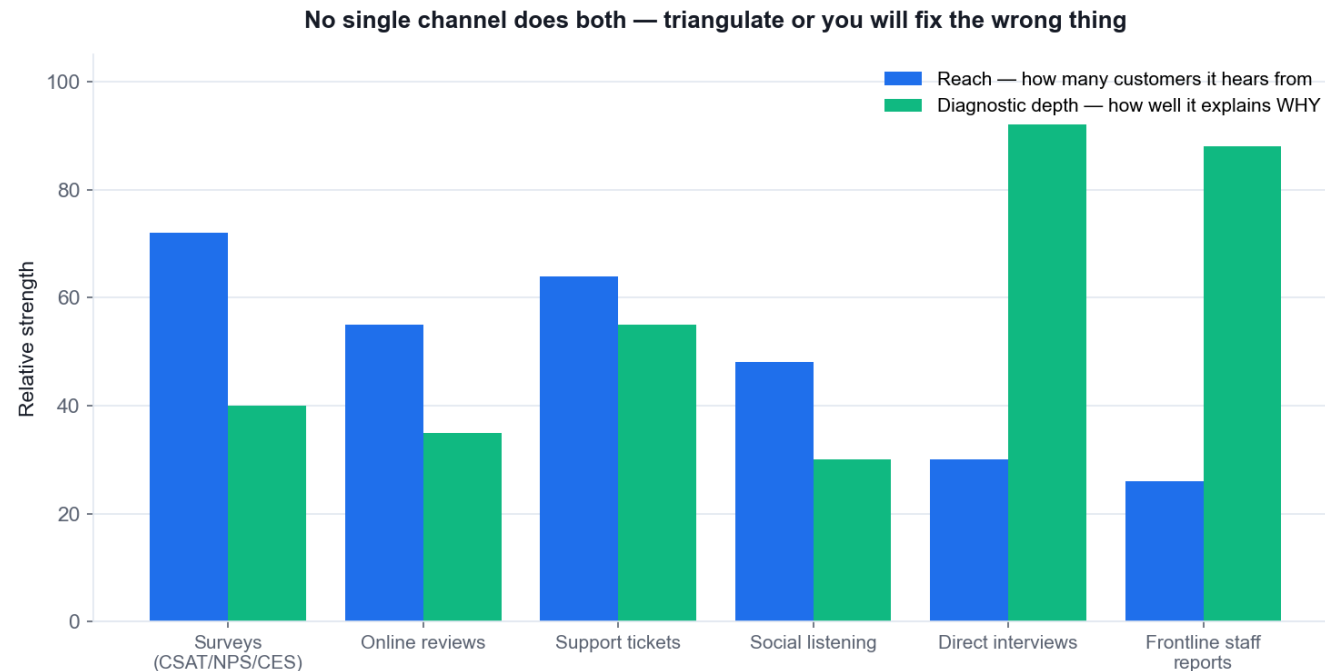
Collect → analyse → act → tell the customer what changed. Feedback with no visible action trains people to stop giving it.

6

### Recovery can beat no failure at all

A well-recovered failure often leaves the customer more loyal than a customer who never had a problem.

# Feedback Channels — Reach vs Diagnostic Depth



## Surveys reach widest

CSAT/NPS/CES cover many customers but rarely explain WHY.

## Interviews go deepest

Few customers, but they surface the mechanism behind the score.

## Staff reports are gold

Frontline staff see causes that customers only experience as symptoms.

## Triangulate always

No single channel does both — one channel alone fixes the wrong thing.

# The Three Service Metrics — and What Each Actually Measures

| Metric | The question it asks                          | What it is good for                                   | Its blind spot                                            |
|--------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| CSAT   | How satisfied were you with this interaction? | A specific moment — one agent, one ticket, one visit. | Says nothing about the overall relationship.              |
| NPS    | How likely are you to recommend us?           | The whole relationship and word-of-mouth risk.        | One number; gives no reason without a follow-up question. |
| CES    | How much effort did you have to spend?        | Predicts disloyalty better than satisfaction does.    | Focuses on friction, not on delight or emotional loyalty. |

Use them together: CSAT for the moment, NPS for the relationship, CES for the friction.

# Most Unhappy Customers Never Complain



## ~4% complain

Only a small fraction ever tell you there is a problem.

## ~56% say nothing

They do not complain, do not answer the survey — they just stop coming back.

## Silence is not health

The absence of complaints is not evidence of satisfaction.

## Go and look

If you only react to complaints, you are managing the visible 4%.

# Closing the Loop — the Only Cycle That Changes Anything



**Feedback with no visible action trains customers to stop giving it.  
The loop is only closed at step 4.**

## Collect

Across every channel, deliberately — including from your own staff.

## Analyse

Separate symptoms from root causes. The wait is a symptom; the staffing gap is the cause.

## Act

An owner, a date and a measure. Anything less is an intention, not an action.

## Tell them

The step everyone forgets — and the only one the customer can see.

Feedback with no visible action trains customers to stop giving it — and your early-warning system goes dark.



# Operational and Personnel Feedback Channels (K3)

1

## Shift huddles and briefings

Short, daily, structured — the fastest route from frontline observation to action.

2

## Frontline incident logs

A written record of what actually happened, not what the system recorded.

3

## Team retrospectives

Regular review of what broke and why, with an owner assigned to each fix.

4

## Internal escalation reports

Patterns in what gets escalated reveal where authority is missing.

5

## Quality assurance scorecards

Reviewed interactions scored for tone, clarity and accuracy.

6

## Suggestion and defect channels

A formal route so a known bug never sits in a WhatsApp group for months.

Customer channels tell you WHAT went wrong. Personnel channels are usually the only ones that tell you WHY.

# Activity 7 — Closing the Loop — F&B Chain Losing Repeat Customers

## THE SCENARIO

Kopi & Co is a Singapore café chain with 9 outlets. Repeat-customer rate has fallen 15% this quarter. Management wants a recovery plan. Here is the feedback that exists:

GOOGLE REVIEWS (rating fell 4.4 → 3.8): 'Waited 25 min for a flat white at Raffles Place, staff seemed overwhelmed.' · 'Ordered on the app, got the wrong drink twice.' · 'Nobody acknowledged me at the counter for 5 minutes.' · 'Food is still great, service has really slipped.'

POST-VISIT SURVEY (CSAT 62%, down from 81%): lowest-scoring item is 'speed of service' (48%); highest is 'product quality' (91%). Only 4% of visitors complete the survey.

**FORMAT** Case Study + Group Presentation

**ROLES** Groups of 4–5. Each group presents a 3-minute plan to the class acting as management.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 7 · Activities folder: activities/activity-07/

## Activity 7 — Discussion Questions

1

Sort every piece of feedback by CHANNEL. What is each channel good at capturing, and what does each one miss?

2

Only 4% complete the survey and CSAT is 62%. What is wrong with concluding '62% of our customers are satisfied'?

3

Separate SYMPTOMS from ROOT CAUSES. The 25-minute wait is a symptom — what is causing it?

4

The staff feedback identifies the app modifier bug that support tickets only show as 'wrong item'. What does that tell you about operational feedback channels?

5

Not one customer who left feedback has heard anything back. What does that cost, beyond this quarter?

6

Build the plan: at least 3 strategies, each with an owner, a timeline and a success measure. What will you measure, and when will you know it worked?

20 minutes · Groups of 4–5. Each group presents a 3-minute plan to the class acting as management.

## Activity 7 — Debrief

Channel biases: reviews capture the extremes (delighted and furious) and skew negative; surveys capture the compliant middle; tickets capture only what customers bothered to report; staff feedback captures CAUSES the other three only show as symptoms.

4% response rate means severe non-response bias — and roughly 56% of unhappy customers never complain at all. 62% CSAT is the score of the 4% willing to answer, not of the customer base.

Root causes are: (1) the June app update dropped the modifier field, (2) Raffles Place is 2 baristas short since May, (3) there is no closed loop so nothing gets fixed. The 25-minute wait and the wrong drinks are downstream of these.

The staff channel had the highest-value diagnostic information in the whole case — and it was sitting in an informal WhatsApp group because no formal operational feedback channel exists. This is exactly K3.

Silence costs the future: customers who give feedback and see nothing change stop giving feedback, and the early-warning system goes dark. The 15% drop is what you can see; the lost channel is what you cannot.

A good plan is specific: 'Ops Manager fixes the modifier field by 5 Sept, measured by wrong-item tickets falling below 10/week' beats 'improve the app'. Push every group to name an owner, a date and a number.

**TEST IT** Your plan names 3 root causes (not symptoms), has an owner and date for every strategy, includes a numeric success measure, and contains an explicit mechanism for telling customers what changed.

TOPIC 08

# Recovering Difficult Customers

De-escalation · HEARD and LAST · common ground · limits · managing your own emotions

## Topic 8 — Key Concepts

1

### **Recovery restores the relationship**

The goal is not only to fix the fault but to rebuild the trust the fault destroyed.

2

### **HEARD framework**

Hear · Empathize · Apologize · Resolve · Diagnose — let them finish, then act, then prevent the recurrence.

3

### **LAST framework**

Listen · Apologize · Solve · Thank — thank them for surfacing a problem you would otherwise not have seen.

4

### **Perceived justice has three parts**

Customers judge the outcome, the process and how they were treated. Fix the fault and still fail on the last two.

5

### **Establish common ground**

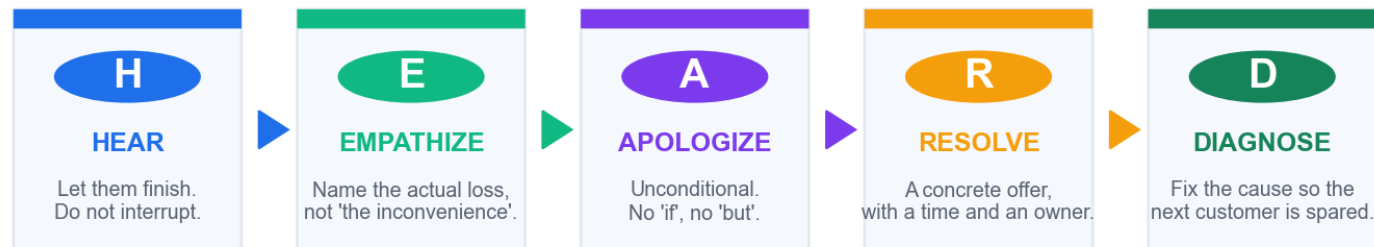
'We both want this resolved fairly today' converts an adversarial exchange into a shared problem.

6

### **Manage yourself first**

Detach from the personal, control breathing and pace, keep language neutral. Composure is the de-escalation tool.

# HEARD — the De-escalation Framework



## WHY IT WORKS

Customers judge the outcome, the process AND how they were treated. HEARD is the only framework that addresses all three — which is why a well-recovered failure can leave a customer more loyal than one who never had a problem.

## Hear then Empathize

Let them finish, then name the actual loss — not 'the inconvenience'.

## Apologize unconditionally

No 'if', no 'but'. A conditional apology is heard as a denial.

## Resolve concretely

An offer with a time and an owner, made now rather than promised later.

## Diagnose the cause

Fix the process so the next customer never meets this problem.

PICK ONE AND USE IT CONSISTENTLY

## Two Recovery Frameworks — HEARD and LAST

| Stage | HEARD     | LAST      | What it achieves                                                |
|-------|-----------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1     | Hear      | Listen    | The customer gets to finish — and you get the real facts.       |
| 2     | Empathize | Apologize | The customer's experience is acknowledged as legitimate.        |
| 3     | Apologize | Solve     | Ownership is taken and a concrete route forward appears.        |
| 4     | Resolve   | Thank     | The problem is fixed — and surfacing it is treated as a favour. |
| 5     | Diagnose  | —         | The root cause is closed so it cannot recur.                    |

LAST is faster for a live counter or call; HEARD adds the Diagnose step that prevents the recurrence.



# Perceived Justice — What the Customer Is Actually Judging

## 1 OUTCOME

Did I get a fair result? The refund, the replacement, the fix. Usually the only part organisations measure.

## 2 PROCESS

Was it fair and reasonable to get there? How long, how many repeats, how many transfers.

## 3 TREATMENT

Was I treated with respect and taken seriously? Often the part that decides whether they return.

## 4 THE TRAP

Fix the outcome, fail the other two, and the customer still leaves — while your metrics show a resolved case.

When you cannot change the outcome, process and treatment are still entirely within your control.

# Managing Yourself in the Difficult Conversation

1

## Establish common ground first

'We both want this resolved fairly today' turns an opponent into a co-problem-solver.

2

## Depersonalise

They are angry at the situation and the company. Absorbing it as a personal attack costs you the next customer too.

3

## Control your physiology

Slow the breath, slow the speech, drop the volume. Composure IS the de-escalation tool.

4

## Set limits once, calmly

State clearly what you can and cannot do. Repeating it or defending it invites haggling.

5

## Never haggle over a loss

Give the maximum you can authorise immediately, then escalate the rest openly and on their side.

6

## Close the loop afterwards

Tell them what changed a week later. That single follow-up converts detractors.

# Activity 8 — Service Recovery Under Pressure — The Wedding Catering Failure

## THE SCENARIO

You are the Duty Manager for a Singapore catering company. Yesterday you catered a 200-guest wedding at a hotel ballroom in Novena. Three failures occurred: the vegetarian main course (40 portions, pre-ordered and confirmed in writing) was never loaded onto the truck; service started 35 minutes late; and the wedding cake was delivered with visible damage to one side.

The bride's father, Mr Wong, paid S\$18,400. He is in your office now. He has photographs. He has already posted a one-star review naming your company. He is demanding a full refund and says he will 'make sure nobody in Singapore uses you again'.

What you know internally: the vegetarian order WAS in the system — the kitchen printed the run sheet before the final amendment was saved, a known gap flagged twice by kitchen staff and never fixed. Your authority extends to a 40% refund; anything beyond that needs the Director, who is contactable.

**FORMAT** Role Play + Case Study

**ROLES** Pairs or trios. A = Duty Manager, B = Mr Wong, C = observer scoring against HEARD.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 8 · Activities folder: activities/activity-08/

## Activity 8 — Discussion Questions

1

Apply HEARD to this case. Write what you would actually SAY at each of the five stages.

2

You cannot undo the wedding. What are you actually recovering, and is recovery even possible here?

3

Mr Wong demands a full refund; you can authorise 40%. How do you set that limit without sounding like you are haggling over his daughter's wedding?

4

The kitchen flagged the run-sheet gap twice and nothing was done. Do you tell Mr Wong that? Argue both sides.

5

Perceived justice has three parts — outcome, process and treatment. Which of the three can you still influence here?

6

Design the process fix. What exactly changes so this cannot happen to the next customer?

## Activity 8 — Debrief

HEARD in practice — Hear: let him show the photographs and finish, however long it takes. Empathize: 'this was your daughter's wedding and we damaged it' — name the actual loss, not 'the inconvenience'. Apologize: unconditional, no 'if' and no 'but'. Resolve: a concrete offer, now. Diagnose: the run-sheet gap, named to him as a real fix.

What you are recovering is not the wedding — it is Mr Wong's standing. He chose this vendor and it failed in front of 200 guests including his extended family. The dignity loss is larger than the money.

Setting the limit: never haggle. State the 40% as immediate and unconditional, then say you are taking the rest to the Director TODAY with your own recommendation, and give a time you will call back. Being on his side of the table is the move.

Disclosing the known gap: strong arguments both ways. Disclosing shows honesty and makes the fix credible; it also hands him evidence of negligence. Most groups land on acknowledging a 'known process gap we failed to close' without the detail that it was flagged twice — accurate, honest, not self-incriminating. There is no single right answer here and the discussion is the point.

Outcome is largely fixed (money is all that is left). But PROCESS and TREATMENT are entirely still in your hands — and research on perceived justice says those two often matter more than the refund amount.

The fix: lock the run sheet against the live order record at print time, or block printing until amendments are closed. Then close the loop — tell Mr Wong what changed, in writing, a week later. That last step is what converts a detractor.

**TEST IT** All five HEARD stages were delivered, your apology contained no conditional words, you set the 40% limit once without haggling, and you produced a written process fix with an owner.

TOPIC 09

# Understanding When to Escalate

Functional vs hierarchical escalation · triggers · the three-strike rule · documentation · POHA

## Topic 9 — Key Concepts

1

### Escalation is a decision, not a failure

Handing over to the right authority or expertise faster is better service than struggling on alone.

2

### Functional vs hierarchical

Functional escalation goes sideways to expertise; hierarchical escalation goes upward to authority.

3

### Angry is not the same as abusive

An angry customer attacks the problem. An abusive customer attacks you — that line is the escalation trigger.

4

### Know the trigger behaviours

Vulgarity, personal insults, discriminatory remarks, legal threats and any threat of physical harm.

5

### The three-strike rule

Two clear, calm warnings that the behaviour must stop, then escalate or end the interaction.

6

### Singapore protects service staff

POHA 2014 criminalises workplace harassment; incidents can go to TAFEP or the police. Document everything.

## THE ESCALATION THRESHOLD

# Where the Line Is — Anger vs Abuse

|                                                                           |                      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| <b>Frustration with the situation</b><br>'This is daylight robbery.'      | <b>SERVE</b>         |
| <b>Criticism of your competence</b><br>'Are you stupid?'                  | <b>SERVE + WARN</b>  |
| <b>THE LINE — anger attacks the problem, abuse attacks the person</b>     |                      |
| <b>Personal / discriminatory abuse</b><br>A slur aimed at you as a person | <b>ESCALATE</b>      |
| <b>Legal threats</b><br>'I'll have your job.'                             | <b>ESCALATE</b>      |
| <b>Physical intimidation</b><br>Within arm's reach, finger in your face   | <b>DURESS + EXIT</b> |

Waiting until you feel physically unsafe means you served through the abuse.

### Anger attacks the problem

Loud, frustrated, even rude about the situation — still serviceable.

### Abuse attacks the person

Slurs, personal or discriminatory attacks. This is the threshold.

### Threats escalate instantly

Legal threats go to a manager; physical threats end the interaction.

### Do not wait to feel unsafe

If you wait for physical fear, you have already served through the abuse.



## Two Kinds of Escalation — Know Which One You Need

### FUNCTIONAL (sideways)

- The issue needs EXPERTISE you do not have.
- Technical faults, billing calculations, specialist products.
- Goes to a specialist team, not up the hierarchy.
- The customer is reasonable — the problem is hard.
- Introduce the specialist and hand over the context.

### HIERARCHICAL (upward)

- The issue needs AUTHORITY you do not have.
- Goodwill beyond your limit, policy exceptions, abuse.
- Goes to a supervisor or duty manager.
- The problem may be simple — your mandate is the constraint.
- Brief your supervisor before they meet the customer.

Same customer and same complaint can need either route — diagnose whether you are short of expertise or short of authority.

## SETTING AND HOLDING THE BOUNDARY

# The Three-Strike Rule in Practice

1

### Warning one — name the behaviour

'I want to help you with this, but I can't continue if you speak to me that way.' Calm, specific, never sarcastic.

2

### Warning two — state the consequence

'If that continues I'll need to hand this to my supervisor and end our conversation.'

3

### Act on it

Escalate or end. A warning you do not act on teaches the customer that the boundary is fictional.

4

### Immediate escalation overrides

Slurs, discriminatory abuse and any physical threat skip the warnings entirely.

5

### Withdraw properly

Hand over in front of the customer, then physically step away. Do not keep serving after escalating.

6

### Document verbatim

Date, time, exact words, witnesses, CCTV reference. Paraphrase destroys the evidence.

# Your Legal Protection in Singapore

1

## **POHA 2014**

The Protection from Harassment Act criminalises harassment, including abuse of workers at work.

2

## **TAFEP**

The Tripartite Alliance for Fair & Progressive Employment Practices takes workplace harassment reports.

3

## **Police report**

Threats of violence and serious harassment are criminal matters, not service problems.

4

## **Employer duty**

Your employer is responsible for providing a workplace safe from harassment.

5

## **Documentation is evidence**

Verbatim wording, times and witnesses are what any report will turn on.

6

## **Aftercare is not optional**

A break, a supervisor debrief and a next-day follow-up after an abusive incident.

'It's part of the job' is not the standard. Singapore law explicitly protects public-facing workers.

# Activity 9 — Drawing the Line — Escalation and Abuse at a Service Counter

## THE SCENARIO

You are a service officer at a telco flagship store on Orchard Road. Mr Douglas Teo is disputing a S\$680 roaming bill from a trip to Australia. He says he was never told data roaming was not included. The account notes show a confirmation SMS was sent and opened. The charge is valid under the contract.

The interaction escalates over 8 minutes:

0:00 He raises his voice: 'This is daylight robbery.'

2:00 'Are you stupid? Can you even read English?'

4:00 He calls you an offensive name related to your race.

5:30 'I'm going to CASE, and I'll have your job. What's your full name and NRIC?'

7:00 He steps behind the counter line, moves within arm's reach, and points a finger in your face.

Other customers are present. Your supervisor is on the shop floor. There is a duress button under the counter and CCTV covering the area.

**FORMAT** Role Play + Decision Exercise

**ROLES** Trios. A = Service Officer, B = Mr Teo (trainer may play this role), C = supervisor/observer.

Full step-by-step instructions: Learner Guide, Activity 9 · Activities folder: activities/activity-09/

## Activity 9 — Discussion Questions

- 1 Go through the timeline. At each timestamp, classify the behaviour as ANGRY or ABUSIVE. Where exactly is the line?
- 2 Which timestamp is the point of no return — where continuing to serve is the wrong decision? Justify it.
- 3 Apply the three-strike rule to this timeline. What are your two warnings, word for word?
- 4 Is this functional escalation or hierarchical escalation? Would your answer change if the dispute were technical rather than behavioural?
- 5 He demands your full name and NRIC. What are you obliged to give, and what are you not?
- 6 At 7:00 he is within arm's reach and pointing at your face. What do you do in the next 5 seconds, in order?
- 7 What must go into the incident report, and why does the exact wording he used need to be recorded verbatim?

## Activity 9 — Debrief

The line: 0:00 and 2:00 are anger directed at the situation and then at your competence — unpleasant but serviceable. 4:00 is the crossing point: a racial slur is abuse of the PERSON and is a criminal matter under POHA, not a service problem.

Point of no return is 4:00, not 7:00. Most learners wait for the physical proximity. Waiting until you feel physically unsafe means you served through the abuse — the threshold is the slur, and it is not negotiable or 'part of the job'.

Warnings must be calm, specific and behavioural: 'Mr Teo, I want to help you with this bill, but I cannot continue if you speak to me that way.' Second: 'If that continues I will need to hand this to my supervisor and end our conversation.' Never sarcastic, never raised.

This is HIERARCHICAL escalation — it needs authority, not expertise. A technical roaming dispute would be FUNCTIONAL escalation to a billing specialist. Same customer, same bill, entirely different escalation path.

You give your first name or staff ID — that is standard and reasonable. You never give your NRIC or personal details. Deflect: 'my name is X and my staff ID is Y, and my supervisor will give you the complaint reference.'

At 7:00, in order: step back to restore distance, keep hands visible and open, do not turn your back, say clearly 'please step back behind the counter', signal or press for the supervisor, and press the duress button if he does not comply. Do not attempt to win the exchange.

The report needs date, time, location, the exact words used verbatim, witnesses present, CCTV reference, actions taken and who was notified. Verbatim matters because POHA and any police report turn on what was actually said — paraphrase destroys the evidence.

**TEST IT** You identified 4:00 as the escalation threshold, delivered two calm behavioural warnings, handed over without continuing to serve, and produced an incident report containing the verbatim wording and a CCTV reference.



WRAP-UP

# Course Summary & Next Steps

# What You Achieved Today

1

## Understood the service chain

External and internal customers, and why service quality is a chain not a department. (LO1)

2

## Built a service attitude

Appearance, smile, energy, positivity and positive language under pressure. (LO1)

3

## Identified customer needs

Active listening, open questioning, and the four levels of addressing needs. (LO1)

4

## Served across every channel

In person, on the phone, and in writing — matching channel to issue. (LO1)

5

## Turned feedback into improvement

Feedback channels, closing the loop, and root cause vs symptom. (LO2)

6

## Recovered and escalated safely

HEARD and LAST, perceived justice, the three-strike rule and POHA. (LO2)



## THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

# **The absence of complaints is not evidence of satisfaction.**

Go and look. Ask your customers, ask your frontline, and close the loop where it matters.

WE'RE HERE TO HELP

# Support

1

## Email

[enquiry@tertiaryinfotech.com](mailto:enquiry@tertiaryinfotech.com)

2

## Telephone

+65 6100 0613

3

## Website

[www.tertiarycourses.com.sg](http://www.tertiarycourses.com.sg)

4

## LMS / TMS portal

[lms-tms.tertiaryinfotech.com](http://lms-tms.tertiaryinfotech.com) — courseware, assessment and certificates.

5

## During the course

Ask your trainer at any point — including during the activities.

6

## After the course

Contact us any time; we support learners after the class ends.

# Final Assessment

1

## Oral Questioning (OQ) — 30 min

3 open-ended questions covering K1, K2 and K3. Individual, open book.

2

## Role Play (RP) — 30 min

2 simulated customer interactions covering A1, A2 and A3. Individual, open book.

3

## Open book

Slides, Learner Guide and approved materials only.

4

## Both must be Competent

You must be assessed Competent in BOTH instruments to pass.

5

## 75% attendance required

Attendance and a Competent result are both needed for funding.

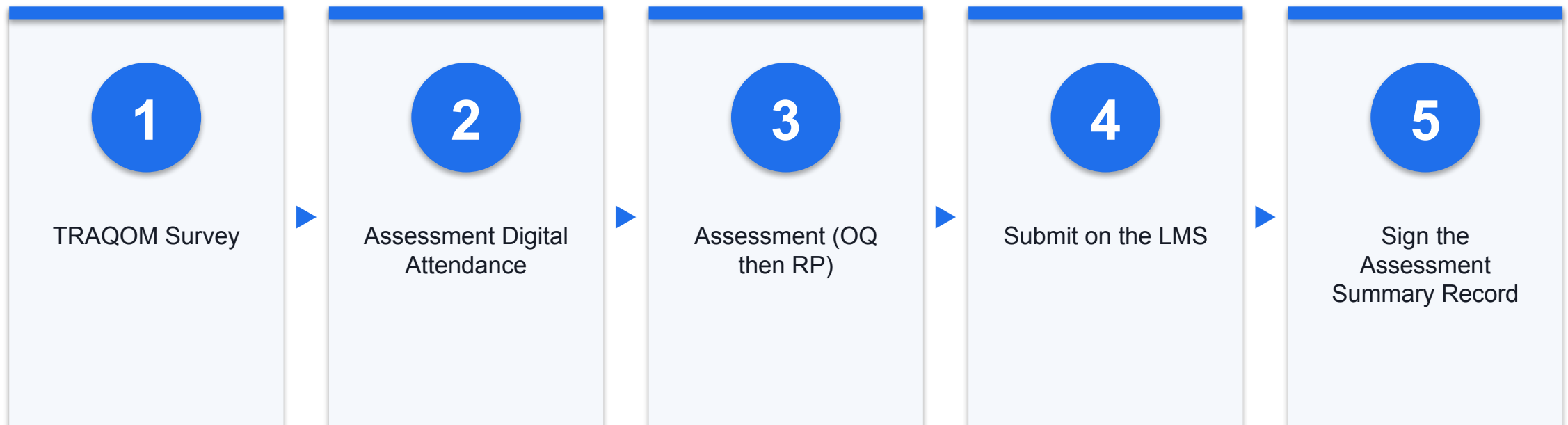
6

## Appeals available

You may appeal if you disagree with the assessment outcome.

Oral Clarification of up to 10 minutes may be conducted 1:1 to close minor performance gaps — this is not counted in the assessment duration.

# Assessment Flow



# Digital Attendance (Mandatory)

1

## Three scans, every course day

AM at the start, PM after lunch, and again before the assessment.

2

## The trainer shows the QR

Generated live from the SSG TRAQOM portal — it changes each session.

3

## Scan with your phone camera

Open the camera, point at the QR, tap the link and submit.

4

## Use your registered details

The NRIC/FIN you enrolled with, or the record will not match.

5

## 75% attendance minimum

Below this you are not eligible for the assessment or for funding.

6

## Tell the trainer immediately

If your scan fails or you arrive late — it cannot be fixed after the day.

Digital attendance is a mandatory SSG funding requirement — it is not the same thing as the TRAQOM feedback survey.

SEE YOU AT THE COUNTER

# Thank You!

You can now collect customer feedback, read what it actually says, and turn it into service that keeps customers.